

Tigers Hit Back

The Rajapakse Government's relentless military onslaught on the LTTE suffers a big blow as the Tigers reinforce their presence with a devastating attack on the Anuradhapura airbase

■ By Christine Jayasinghe in Colombo

Just when the Sri Lankan Government thought it had the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) on the mat, the rebels bounced back with a daring attack displaying their hallmark of tenacity, meticulous planning and coordination. In their biggest-ever operation, Black Tigers suicide bombers mounted a two-pronged attack—ground assault backed by air strikes—at the airbase at Anuradhapura, 210 km north of Colombo on October 22. The devastating assault which killed 13 security personnel, including two pilots, and injuring 22 others, proves that the rebels still pack a punch.

According to LTTE, a 21-member squad of Black Tigers had destroyed eight aircraft, including an advanced

Beechcraft spy plane. However, military sources said only three aircraft, two Mi-24 helicopter gunships and a K-8 trainer aircraft were damaged, while a helicopter that was sent in to provide assistance to the airbase had crashed due to "technical problems".

The Anuradhapura base, which is close to but not in the north and east battle zone, was considered one of the safest and closely guarded air force installations. The airbase provided logistics support to Sri Lankan positions in the north and the assault comes as a body blow to the military. "The attack was meant to cripple the logistics capability of the Sri Lankan Army. It will take them weeks, perhaps months to recover," rebel spokesperson Rasaih Ilanthirayan told INDIA TODAY.

The assault by Black Tigers, which is trained to inflict maximum death

and destruction, is the worst against the military since LTTE deployed its Tamil Eelam Air Force, comprising Czech-made aircraft, in March and April this year to bomb an airbase in Katunayake near Colombo, adjacent to the island nation's only international airport, and government and private oil installations.

However, in Monday's attack, the base was infiltrated by a group of Black Tigers, including three women, in camouflage uniforms similar to those worn by the Sri Lankan Army. About an hour after they began their assault, two LTTE planes flew over the airbase dropping bombs, making the raid the first-ever combined operation in which the rebels deployed both ground forces and air power. Military sources said around 20 Tiger suicide bombers were killed in the operation. The Tigers say the strike marks part



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WAR ZONE

SEPTEMBER 2006: Army captures strategic Tiger-held Sampur town in the east.

MARCH-APRIL 2007: Air Tigers raid airbase near Colombo airport, followed by bombing on oil storage tanks.

JULY 2007: Army evicts Tigers from eastern bases and mobilises for northern offensive. Navy destroys LTTE shipping fleet supplying weapons.

OCTOBER 2007: LTTE strikes at Anuradhapura airbase.

FOILED: Slain Tiger rebels

